

Figure 1: Ubuntu desktop after installation

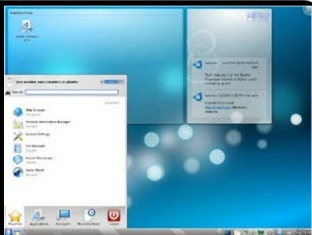


Figure 2: Live Kubuntu desktop with the Kickoff menu and µBlog widget

Now it's time for Kubuntu. At first glance, it's the same boot from Jaunty, and the stock KDE 4.3.2 without any customisations (see Figure 2). But look again and it's a whole new story. It's KMS here too, but this time KMS is a lot more subtle and at least the boot on non-KMS machines looks as good, if not better, than in Jaunty. With KMS on VirtualBox, those transition effects and the flicker-free boot experience did wonders. Boot into KDE4, and the KDM theme just blows you away. Enter your login details and you'll be looking at the prettiest stock KDE4 you have ever seen. And mind you, KDE looks best in its stock theme. Change the looks even a tiny bit and you'll cause a major wardrobe malfunction (or fashion disaster, however you want to put it)!

Kubuntu's installer is another brilliant feature. A full screen image background modelled on the Air theme, with an installer wizard in the centre, guides you through the system installation.

I had a few complaints about Ubuntu, but have none for Kubuntu! None, except for font-rendering issues with

OpenOffice.org, but I'm pretty sure that's because of the fact that OOo is running under Qt. OOo never did like Qt!

OpenSUSE 11.2—The Wow starts now!

Remember January 30, 2007? With a troupe dancing in front of the Taj Mahal, Microsoft Corporation released Windows Vista worldwide on that day. The catch line for the OS? "The Wow Starts Now!". Back then, the company was justified in saying so. But not any more. Enter openSUSE 11.2 and you are sure to get blown away! Let's see what has been done...

KDE 4.3, to start with. Yes, the team has actually gone ahead and customised KDE4, and what a job it has done! The default Air theme has been used, with the thinner panel (this was what actually made me switch to KDE4 full time), and the thick obnoxious green has been replaced by a lighter moss shade (see Figure 4). In fact, the wallpaper is just the default Air wallpaper painted moss colour, with Air-like discs drawn over it. Wow!

Frankly, GNOME 2.28 looks new (see Figure 5). The problem with Ubuntu was that you felt like you were using the same old GNOME. With openSUSE, GNOME doesn't exactly feel like GNOME. It feels better. Everything, from the icon scheme, the dark taskbar, the wallpaper, and the single-panel design, to the custom launcher and the colour scheme, just gels together and creates one hell of a user experience. They call it Sonar. I say 'Wow'. This is GNOME at its best.

The other stuff is SUSE-typical. No sub-pixel rendering support in freetype, Cairo and XFT makes fonts look ultra-ugly—the fix is mentioned later. No multimedia support by default—the fix is mentioned later.

On the software front, they seem to have done some homework. SocioNet now has a privileged place in the operating system, with Choqok and Gwibber, two new micro-blogging clients, of which the latter now supports Facebook. Kopete also now supports Facebook Chat (Oorah!) and new plasmoids are on the cards for Twitter,

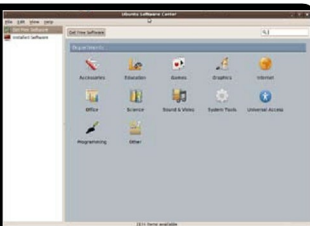


Figure 3: Ubuntu Software Centre—a one-stop app store